

no job but no debt either. Two years into their marriage, she became very sick, the result of a chronic illness she'd been battling all her life. Her long stay in the hospital threw her into \$12,000 of unexpected debt. His wife, he said, wanted to pay back the medical debt entirely on her own. After all, she was the one who got sick; it wasn't fair to make her husband pay it back. He said they argued about it for a while. As her husband and someone who could afford the debt with no problem, Ed insisted he take care of it. He said they compromised, and his wife paid half of it.

Does marrying someone imply all debt—credit card, medical, student loan—is a collective problem now (to be together “for richer or for poorer,” as it were)? The issue of one spouse having debt that the other one isn't necessarily responsible for could cause a lot of resentment for a less emotionally and financially secure couple. Ed and his wife's situation came as a surprise to them, but what about if you're marrying someone who already has debt? What if one partner is better off but certainly doesn't have enough to cover any of their spouse's debts?

HuffPost senior relationships editor Ashley Rockman, who got married in September 2016, says that because student loans are so common today, debt shouldn't necessarily be an automatic deal breaker. It *is* incredibly important, however, that your potential partner has a concrete plan in place for paying it off. If your partner has debt and either isn't working to pay it off or doesn't seem to understand the gravity of owing large sums of money, that's a huge red flag. It could also indicate problematic personality traits that might cause issues down the road.

Before she was the relationships editor, Rockman, 30, oversaw *HuffPost*'s Divorce section. She said the experience showed her that tying yourself to someone in the eyes of the government is more than just a fairy tale. It's a legal contract like any other.

My mom, the divorce and child custody attorney, agreed: “I have had people decide not to marry as a result of the pre-nup negotiations because they get to